



AI-Ready School

Sneak peek

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# My Digital Footprint

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## DIGITAL CITIZENSHIP MINI LESSON · GRADES 3–6

# My digital footprint

Every game, app, video, and AI chatbot a kid uses leaves footprints — not on the ground, but on a screen somewhere. This ten-minute lesson makes an invisible idea visible, then hands students a habit that works on anything with a login, including AI.

## THE BIG IDEA

**If it's typed, tapped, or searched, it can leave a footprint somewhere.**  
**Some footprints fade fast. Some don't. Act like they don't.**

## Teach it (5 minutes, read aloud or in your own words)

Ask: "If you walked across wet sand, would there be a footprint after you walked away?" Yes — for a while, until the tide comes in. Now ask: "What about typing your name into a search bar, or asking an AI chatbot a question?" That can leave a footprint too — but it might not fade like sand does. Some websites and apps keep a record of what you typed for a long time, even after you close the tab.

That doesn't mean the internet is scary. It means we leave footprints on purpose, the way we'd choose our path across sand — not every step, everywhere, without thinking.

## Sort it: footprint or not?

Read each one aloud. Thumbs up if it leaves a footprint, thumbs down if it doesn't.

| Does this leave a digital footprint?                | Footprint? |
|-----------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Typing your full name into a website's sign-up form | Yes        |
| Asking a search engine a question                   | Yes        |
| Thinking about a question in your head              | No         |
| Typing a question into an AI chatbot                | Yes        |
| Talking to a friend at recess, out loud             | No         |
| Posting a comment or a photo online                 | Yes        |
| Writing in a paper journal you keep at home         | No         |

## Activity: green light, red light

### GREEN LIGHT — OKAY TO SHARE

A username you made up · your favorite color · a game score · a question about how something works

### RED LIGHT — KEEP IT OFFLINE

Your full name and address · your school's name · a photo of your face · your birthday and age together

Have students sort five more examples of their own into green light / red light — then check each other's work. Disagreements are the best part of this activity.

## The rule to remember

**Before you type it, ask: "Would I want a stranger to have this?"** If yes, it's probably fine. If no, leave it out — or ask a grown-up first. This same rule works for search engines, games, apps, and AI chatbots.

## Talk about it

- **"What's one footprint you've left today, without thinking about it?"** Most kids can name three or four once they start looking.
- **"Does a footprint ever go away?"** Some fade, some don't — the honest answer is "you often can't tell which," so it's safer to assume it sticks.
- **"What would you want a stranger to *not* know about you?"** That list is the one worth protecting most.

Ten minutes now, revisited whenever a new app or AI tool comes up — the habit generalizes to anything with a login.

**Keep going:** our free Internet Safety with AI one-pager and "Is It True?" fact-checking lesson build on this same habit. Both in our TpT store.

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